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Exploring the role of front-line employees as innovators

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This article aims for a deeper understanding of front-line employees (FLEs) and their boundary-spanning role in service organizations' innovation processes from the vantage points of creativity and service innovation theory. It explores in particular FLEs' processes of creativity by focusing on how ideas emerge and how these ideas are further managed in the organizations' innovation processes. It draws on an in-depth empirical study of three units at a large spa and resort hotel. The article demonstrates how FLEs' ideas are related to the assimilation and utilization of knowledge gained in the customer–supplier interface. Furthermore, it introduces the concept of 'management by weaving', which encompasses the middle managers' roles in the complexity of leading diverse innovation processes in the service organization. By having the roles of facilitator, gatekeeper, and translator, middle managers hold the key position for letting FLEs play the role as innovators.

Keywords: service innovation; idea creation; front-line employees; knowledge utilization; middle managers

Introduction

In today's rapidly changing environment, organizations strive to achieve competitive advantage through innovation. Creativity and innovation are not just a result of firms' strategies and overall access to resources, but, more fundamentally, also stem from the individual employees, who themselves or with others carry out the work of the organization every day (Amabile, Schatzel, Moneta, & Kramer, 2004). While doing their job, employees gain knowledge that might induce new ideas in the form of novel products or procedures, which, when implemented, might become organizational innovations.

As individual creativity provides the foundation for organizational creativity and innovation (Amabile, 1988; Shalley & Gilson, 2004), employees represent a valuable asset for the firm. Though the importance of creativity and the level of creativity needed will differ depending on elements such as the task, the organization, and the business, one can assume that there is room for creativity in just about every job (Shalley & Gilson, 2004). Within the service sector, the significance of the front-line employees (FLEs) as a driver for business success in general is an acknowledged factor (Cadwallader, Jarvis, Bitner, & Ostrom, 2010). In today's competitive environment where customers desire and expect customized services, the employees working in the front line interacting with the customers are through their adaptive behaviours characterized as the heart of a firm's ability to deliver this type of

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customized service (Gwinner, Bitner, Brown, & Kumar, 2005, p. 144). At the same time, it is possible for employees to learn and gain valuable knowledge from the customers (Matthing, Sandén, & Edvardsson, 2004). This boundary-spanning role that FLEs take on points towards two important factors. First, one can assume that the employees' capacity to be flexible and adapt to the customers partly will be based on their creativity. Second, knowledge regarding the customers that the employees absorb will be important to incorporate in the organizations' innovation processes. Hence, FLEs represent a vital asset for the creative and innovative activities in service organizations, and a critical challenge for the organization is to facilitate and utilize the resource they represent.

Despite the innovative potential of front-line service employees, in general little knowledge exists regarding innovation processes on a micro-level (van der Aa & Elfring, 2002; Crevani, Palm, & Schilling, 2011) and on creativity among FLEs in particular (Coelho, Augusto, & Lages, 2011; Wong & Ladkin, 2008). The role of employees in service organizations is however of particular interest since service innovations rarely are R&D-based (Sundbo & Gallouj, 2000; Tether, 2005) and consequently may be more dependent on employees' input in general. In order to identify how firms can facilitate the creative individual, like FLEs, it is essential to have some understanding of the requirements for creative thought and the characteristics of their work style (Mumford, 2000). Though we can argue that the FLEs are in a position to be creative and have valuable ideas, we need to know more about the process and the outcome.

Accordingly, the purpose of this study is to gain a deeper understanding of the FLEs and their boundary-spanning role in service organizations' innovation processes. The article explores in particular the employees' creativity processes by focusing on how ideas from FLEs emerge, and furthermore examines how these ideas are subsequently developed and managed in the organizations' innovation processes.

Previous empirical studies on organizational creativity are to a great extent laboratory studies or quantitative field studies. This study takes a qualitative in-depth approach, and thus responds to Zhou and Shalley's (2003) call for more qualitative research on creativity. To comprehend the boundary-spanning role of FLEs in regard to creativity fully, we explore the type of ideas that FLEs create and how their creative processes are linked to organizational innovation activities. Though the concepts of creativity and innovation are strongly related, which the literature acknowledges, empirical studies rarely show the link between them. Research on organizational creativity and employees' creativity focuses on how we can enhance creativity, identify barriers, and understand managerial practices. But less is understood regarding the process based on employee-created ideas and its implementation later on (Axtell, Holman, Unsworth, Wall, & Waterson, 2000). Using a qualitative approach, we are able to gain knowledge on what influences FLEs' creative processes from their perspective, and we can also track the employees' ideas further along in organizations' innovation process, as well as their possible implementation or rejection.

First, this article presents a theoretical framework for understanding the main factors that influence FLEs' ability to create ideas at work and to engage in service organizations' innovative activities. Next, the method chosen for the study is described before the findings are presented. The article ends with a discussion of theoretical and practical implications, followed by suggestions for further research.

Theoretical background

Innovation and creativity

Innovation is often defined as the implementation of the ideas, whereas creativity is related to the production of the ideas (Amabile, Conti, Coon, Lazenby, & Herron, 1996; Shalley, Zhou, & Oldham, 2004). Thus, 'creativity is a necessary (but not sufficient) factor enabling innovation' (Carayannis & Gonzalez, 2003, p. 587). A commonly understood definition of creativity is the development of ideas on products, practices, services, or procedures that are both *novel* and *potentially useful* to the organization (Oldham & Cummings, 1996; Shalley et al., 2004). Creative ideas may thus range from incremental suggestions to radical organizational changes, just as long as the idea is both unique compared with other ideas within the organization and might provide potential value for the organization (Mumford & Gustafson, 1988; Shalley et al., 2004). However, the value of an idea is realized first when it is implemented, which links creativity to innovation.

Service innovation

The service innovation process is often characterized as less formalized compared with that of physical products. The process is also usually linked to the actual service delivery process (Ettlie & Rosenthal, 2011; Sundbo, 1997, 2008; Toivonen, 2010). Sundbo (2008, p. 27) describes a service as a behavioural act, and thus service innovations are fundamentally a renewal of human behaviour. In the service context, special emphasis is often given to the client–supplier interface (i.e. the customer and the FLE) (Toivonen & Tuominen, 2009). In many service contexts, such as the hospitality sector, the host–guest transaction is viewed as the core activity (Onsøyen, Mykletun, & Steiro, 2009). Hence, one can assume that this interaction represents a focal point for innovating activities and processes.

Service innovations can be the result of a planned, strategic process or a more unstructured, ad hoc-based process, or both. The latter process is often connected to 'ad hoc innovations', defined as 'a solution to a particular problem posed by a given client' (Gallouj & Weinstein, 1997, p. 549), where the executed adjustment needs to be reproducible in a new situation (Gallouj, 2002). Furthermore, Toivonen and Tuominen (2009) have found in their studies two more processes that lead to innovation. One is 'rapid application', where an idea is brought to the market and, if successful, is then further developed. The other is the 'practice-driven model' (or the a posteriori model) (Toivonen, 2010), where a change in the service practice is acknowledged in retrospect as an innovation and consequently developed further (Toivonen & Tuominen, 2009). Fuglsang and Sørensen (2011) have introduced an additional interrelated innovation; innovation as bricolage or tinkering. This is defined as 'a change of structure and adjustment of protocol which is created from resources at hand' (Fuglsang & Sørensen, 2011, p. 584). In all three types of innovations, ad hoc, practice-driven, and bricolage, the customer–employee interaction is central. Hence, employees who interact with the customers are also likely to come up with ideas, ideas that might immediately be implemented (e.g. bricolage) or are in the need of further development, or both. As ideas are ignited and created by employees, their ability to be creative will most likely influence their organization's innovation activities.

Employee creativity

Though every employee may be creative, not everyone is. An employee's creativity can be described by a framework where creativity is a function of personal characteristics, characteristics of the organizational context, and the interactions among these characteristics (Amabile, 1988; Shalley & Gilson, 2004; Woodman, Sawyer, & Griffin, 1993). According to Amabile (1988), individual creative performance is affected by three components: domain-relevant skills, creativity-relevant skills, and intrinsic task motivation. Collectively, this is known as the 'componential model'. The first component, domain-relevant skills, is the foundation for all creative work, consisting of factual knowledge, technical skills, and special talents. It is thus a type of a personal expert knowledge within a specific domain. The second component, creativity-relevant skills, includes the ability to take new perspectives on problems and refers to how individuals approach problems and solutions (Amabile, 1988). The first two components should be regarded as creative capability, while it is the third component, intrinsic task motivation, that determines the actual outcome that people will accomplish (Amabile, 1988). Whereas task motivation in general includes the individuals' attitudes towards a specific task and their perception of the motivation for doing or working on the task (Zhou & Shalley, 2003), intrinsic task motivation refers to the motivation to engage in a task primarily for its own sake, because it is interesting, engaging, or in some way satisfying. Intrinsically motivated people have been found to be more creative than those who are extrinsically motivated and work primarily to receive rewards or recognition or to fulfil a command (Eisenberger & Shanock, 2003; Hennessey, 2000).

The three components are building blocks for creativity; all are necessary in order to accomplish some level of creativity. Furthermore, the higher the level of each of the three components, the higher the level of overall creativity (Amabile, 1988, p. 137). In the next section, we shall discuss how the components for individual creativity can stimulate FLEs in their creative work.

Front-line employees' antecedents for creativity

In short, to come up with new creative ideas FLEs need to have knowledge concerning the domain of the task, some general creative skills, and motivation to do the actual task. But since innovation might emerge through interactions between customers and employees, enabling employees to act upon ideas is vital.

From a perspective of knowledge, at least two types of knowledge can be discerned as necessary to succeed with innovation: supply-side knowledge and demand-side knowledge (von Hippel, 1994; Ozer, 2009). Supply-side knowledge is necessary to understand how ideas are supposed to be implemented, and thus it is a focus on issues of feasibility, including both technical and organizational issues, which is also called 'technology knowledge' (Magnusson, 2009) or 'technical knowledge' (Lüthje, 2004). The demand-side knowledge, also called 'use knowledge' (Magnusson, 2009) or 'use experience' (Lüthje, 2004), concerns the understanding of how user or customer value is created through the use of underlying technology. The supply and demand sides are complementary: the supplier side looks upon the idea from the company's perspective and the demand side takes the customer's view. Both the supply and demand sides of knowledge are necessary to activate, to accomplish, and, accordingly, to evaluate innovation (von Hippel, 1994; Kanter, 1988). On the one hand, FLEs know their work domain and practices, that is, the work they perform. On the other hand, they get to know the customers through the interaction. It is thus reasonable to expect that FLEs have or are in a position to gain both types of knowledge.

In order to innovate, organizations need not only knowledgeable individuals, but also employees who are able to initiate a process that breaks free from the organization's established routines or practices (Kanter, 1988). Breaking existing routines and practices in a service organization can be the start for a new way of doing things and can become an innovation, which is either directly implemented (bricolage) or adopted by the organization for further development, as described in the practice-driven model. This requires people who are able and willing to pay attention and to sense opportunities. Close customer or user contact is known as an important innovation activator (de Brentani, 2001; Kanter, 1988; Ordanini & Parasuraman, 2011). It should, however, be noted that (too much) technology knowledge has been found to be a hindrance to creativity because people tend not to stretch beyond what is currently possible (Magnusson, 2009; Marsh, Bink, & Hicks, 1999). Too much technology knowledge can thus be a burden for creativity.

Interaction with others has consistently been referred to in the research on creativity as a necessary precondition for creative performance (Shalley & Gilson, 2004). Groups and their characteristics have been the subjects of numerous studies, and studies of work environment in general show that employees are more likely to be creative when working with supportive and nurturing co-workers (Amabile et al., 1996; Zhou & George, 2001). Care is also central when leadership styles and organizational encouragement are studied. The vast majority of earlier studies provide substantial positive support for supportive leadership and intrinsic motivation (Shalley et al., 2004). There is no reason to assume that a nurturing work environment should be any less important in service organizations than they are in other industries. There is a challenge involved with service organizations, however. FLEs engage constantly with customers through their work, and leaders might struggle to be close enough to the work practices to follow-up on the potentially useful new ideas and knowledge that evolve from the practice.

Research framework

On the basis of the aforementioned research, Figure 1 represents a framework for studying how the FLEs generate ideas and subsequently the process of further elaborating the ideas. Amabile's (1988) componential model is used as an analytical framework for the first part of the study, which explores FLEs' process of creativity by looking at how the factors of domain knowledge, creative skills, and motivation affect FLEs' creativity. Amabile's model is germane because its components that identify the influences on a person's ability to be creative in general have been thoroughly empirically tested and are widely accepted (see e.g. Shalley et al., 2004; Zhou & Shalley, 2003). However, it should be noted that the purpose of the study is not to confirm the established model, but to use it as an analytical lens for understanding the processes that take place in FLE innovation. Accordingly, this study takes a flexible approach owing to the need to adapt the componential model to this context. In particular, Amabile focuses on intrinsic motivation, but there is a paucity of research done on FLEs. Thus, one cannot just rule out the effect of extrinsic motivation (e.g. monetary rewards), which has in some studies been shown to affect creativity (Shalley et al., 2004). Accordingly, the framework in this article refers to the concept of motivation in general. Furthermore, on the basis of the FLEs' role as boundary workers,

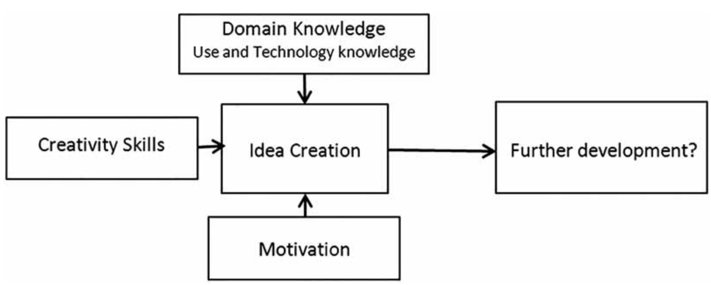

Figure 1. Antecedents to idea creation in the front line.

the study explores the type of knowledge related to this role, and hence distinguishes between use knowledge and technology knowledge. Besides drawing attention to the antecedents to idea creation, the framework employed here points to the question of how ideas are managed and then transformed into innovations. The study aims to gain more knowledge of the link between idea creation and innovation, thus following the whole innovation process.

Method

An in-depth study of a large spa and resort hotel located in Sweden was performed in order to learn more about how the FLEs' ideas emerge and are managed in the organization's innovation processes. This study chose a tourism and hospitality case, a SPA-resort, on the basis of how the increasing market expectations to experience something new and meaningful might influence the need for FLEs to be flexible and creative at work (Boswijk, Thijssen, & Peelen, 2007). A single-case study was conducted owing to the need to carry out a comprehensive study where the data would make it possible to make comparisons within a single organization, instead of comparisons between cases (Stake, 2003; Yin, 2009). This approach will provide new insight into the FLEs' idea-creation process, the potential similarity and differences between the employees, and the follow-up on the ideas. Furthermore, the SPA-resort, with a total of 95 permanent employees, consists of three more or less independent entities or units: Hotel (i.e. reception and beds), restaurant and bar, and spa and fitness unit. All three units have unique services and facilities but are integrated under the same roof and serve the same customers. This characteristic enabled a comparison between three different contexts in which both the employees and the managers could be studied, as will be discussed in the findings.

Data collection

Data were collected through interviews and observations. Internal and external documents were also collected. Interviews were conducted mainly with FLEs, but in addition some back-office personnel and managers of the units were interviewed. A total of 22 interviews were conducted: 13 with FLEs, 7 with managers, and the remaining 2 with employees who worked primarily in the back office, but who had tasks that enabled them to observe the customers' use of the services (e.g. housekeeper). In line with the recommendations made by several innovation scholars (Veldhuizen, Hultink, & Griffin, 2006), we used multiple informants with different functional backgrounds. Of the employees, 5 came from the hotel, 4 from the restaurant, and 6 from the spa and fitness unit. The interviews focused on idea creation and involvement in the organization's innovation process. An interview guide was used, where questions were aimed at identifying the main factors in the FLEs' idea-creation process, as seen in Figure 1. In addition, questions were aimed at following up on the further processing of the ideas, and the employees' involvement in the organization's innovation processes. On the basis of these considerations, this study deemed it critical to capture the employees' own perceptions and perspectives of idea creation and innovation, and it emphasized the need to follow-up on what the employees called attention to. Interviews lasted between 30 minutes and 1:15 hours (effective time), for a total of 16 hours. All interviews were transcribed as soon as possible. Several rounds of interviews were conducted, which made adaptions possible as data were analysed on an on-going basis.

Observations were conducted of internal meetings focused on generation of ideas. When appropriate, notes were taken during the observation. In addition, a wide range of documents were collected, including written presentations, reports, service development schemes, and so on. The data were triangulated for reliability through the comparison of the different data sources with each other. When empirical saturation was achieved, the data collection was terminated.

Data analysis

In order to analyse the role of the FLEs in the innovation processes, a 'thematic analysis' (Boyatzis, 1998) was used, in line with the recommendations of Braun and Clark (2006). They suggest a six-phase analysis, beginning with familiarizing oneself with the data, through generating codes, searching, and reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and ending with the final phase, the write-up. Though some of the factors that influence creativity are well known and established a priori in the research model, the thematic approach was chosen to gain the FLEs' perception of the process for idea creation. A condensed description of the analysis is provided below.

Codes based on our research questions were identified, framed as 'how do the ideas from FLEs emerge?' and 'how are these ideas subsequently developed and managed in the organizations' innovation processes?' After the initial coding, both researchers analysed all the codes individually in order to uncover relationships between the codes that could form different themes. This resulted in a list of 10 preliminary themes: (1) getting ideas based on situations, (2) getting ideas based on people, (3) getting ideas based on the personality, (4) kind of ideas, (5) why ideas, (6) value of the ideas, (7) organizational factors, (8) what motivates, (9) connection to management, and (10) the process. Each theme was interpreted in order to understand the underlying meaning; the next phase used the interpretations to review and modify the themes. Through reviewing and defining the themes, corresponding to Phases 4 and 5 in Braun and Clark (2006), the analysis resulted in one of the candidate themes being discarded and some being merged, resulting in different levels of themes. In this part of the analyse process, it is vital that data within the themes cohere together meaningfully, at the same time that they are distinct in between. Furthermore, the themes must be considered to the data set, that they reflect the meanings evident in the data set as a whole (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Thus as a result, the first 10 themes were redefined into 5 main themes, one blurred with several others and therefore rejected (10), the other 4 fitted into subthemes in other to be distinct from each other. The five themes were (the preliminary in parenthesis): (1) the triggers of idea creation (1–2), (2) the creator of the ideas (3), (3) motivation for idea creation (5, 6, 7, and 8), (4) type of ideas created (4), and (5) elaboration of the ideas (9). These themes emerged primarily from the interviews with FLEs and back-office employees. Moreover, the interviews with managers were analysed according to the themes. In addition, the interviews with the unit managers at the restaurant/bar (food and beverage manager), the hotel (hotel manager), and the spa/fitness (spa manager) along with the CEO of the SPA-resort were analysed separately, where there was a particular focus on if and how managers emphasize ideas from their staff and to which degree this is something that is fostered within the units. Analysing the idea-creation and the organization's innovation processes from two perspectives, that is, FLEs and management, made it possible to examine how the two groups relate to each other in idea-creation and subsequent development processes. Looking at the three units separately also made it possible to compare the processes within the SPA-resort. In the next section, we present our findings, first by connecting the themes to build on the previous model, and then by displaying the data to support the findings as shown in Figure 2.

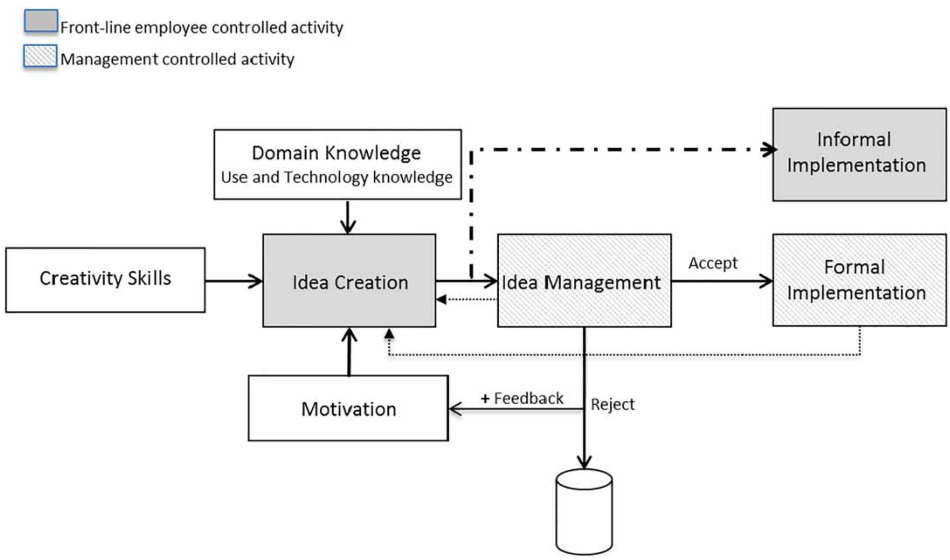

Figure 2. Antecedents to and consequences of idea creation in the front line.

Findings

The themes presented above depict the service innovation process, from the FLEs' idea creation to their implementation. The five themes are closely connected and through this connection the processes for idea creation and further development can best be understood. The themes encompass three activities: (1) idea creation, (2) idea management, and (3) implementation, thus portraying the FLEs' innovation process. Furthermore, this process includes both management's and employees' controlled activities. How the themes fit within the activities and the processes is described more in detail below and is illustrated in Figure 2.

The first activity represents idea creation. As the research framework illustrates (Figure 1), employees' ability to create ideas, or their creative process, can be analysed by using the component model for individual creativity as defined by Amabile (1988). The components comprise domain knowledge, motivation, and creativity skills, and together they should reflect the basic understanding for creativity. As stated, a central object for the FLE interviews was to study the FLEs' own perspective of the innovation process, and all three factors, albeit to different degrees, are reflected in the themes that emerged through the analysis. The first two themes, 'the triggers of idea creation' and 'the creator of the ideas', cover the employees' reflections on elements involving knowledge and characteristics of their own personality. The second only partly points to creative skills and the employees' cognitive skills are not represented in the findings. The third theme, 'motivation for idea creation', represents their thoughts on what motivates them to come up with ideas.

In our research framework (Figure 1), the further development of the ideas follows idea creation. In the analysis of our data, we found that the further development consisted of two parts, idea management and implementation. In idea management, ideas are either rejected or accepted for further development and implementation. The unit manager – who we found to have multiple roles – makes the actual evaluation and plays a critical part in linking idea creation to further formal implementation of the ideas. As illustrated in Figure 2, this phase was also found to have an influence on idea creation. Feedback to the FLEs regarding the evaluation was vital for motivating the FLEs' creativity and in many ways decided whether they regarded work practice to be open to new ideas or not. In addition, managers were also in a position to influence the employees' creativity directly through, for example, actively facilitating idea creation. We shall see below that the manager could either be engaged in and initiate the innovation processes or be more reluctant and uninvolved.

Furthermore, as seen in Figure 2, we also found a shortcut, an informal process for implementing FLEs' ideas. These are the ideas that FLEs themselves are in control of and can realize without involving the management. The ideas are embedded within the work practice, what we referred to earlier as a bricolage innovation, which alters the employees' practices. Both the formal and informal paths to innovation are based on Themes 4 and 5, that is, the types of ideas created and how the ideas are elaborated. The next section elaborates the findings illustrated in Figure 2. Though the activities are portrayed as stages in a linear process, the process will in practice take on the form of reinforcing loops. How idea management is led influences idea creation, and having ideas implemented can also influence the employees' process of idea creation, as shown in Figure 2.

Idea creation

In this section, we focus on the initial innovation activity in the front line, the idea-creation process, by examining the knowledge ideas were based on, who created ideas, and the motivational factors for coming up with ideas.

Domain knowledge

The FLEs at the SPA-resort all expressed the opinion that the workplace represents a platform for learning opportunities, primarily based on interactions with customers and co-workers. As a boundary worker, the FLEs share meeting arenas with customers and co-workers. These arenas gave rise to new employee ideas on the basis of either direct interaction face-to-face with the customers or by observing them. In addition to gaining knowledge from inside the SPA-resort, the majority of the interviewees reported how external sources also led to ideas. These three learning sources – customers, co-workers, and external information in addition to the knowledge initially held by the FLEs – gave the employees an opportunity to gain and act on new knowledge. Table 1 illustrates the quotations from employees at the SPA-resort that state how ideas came about and they reflect the different learning sources. The quotations illustrate situations or actions that can be related to either customer (use) knowledge, organizational (technology) knowledge, or a combination of them.

As seen in Table 1, FLEs gain use knowledge by being approached directly by the customers (e.g. quotations no. 1–2 in Table 1). In addition, the employees also observe the customers, and they repeatedly stated that this was a way of coming up with new ideas (e.g. quotation no. 4 in Table 1). The restaurant manager at the SPA-resort gave an example, where the functionality of the buffet was improved by reducing the queues to get drinks by placing them directly at the table. This small adaption of the service delivery process was introduced after observations of the customers in the restaurant.

Technology knowledge is related to the employees' formal competences as well as their knowledge of the organization in general and its practices and resources in particular. Thus, technology knowledge can be seen as the competences necessary for FLEs to perform their

Table 1. Front-line employees-related practices for domain-relevant knowledge.

No.	Quotations from FLEs	Use knowledge	Technology knowledge
1.	Sometimes you hear a guest saying something, which you catch up. You can get a lot of ideas from the customers. Some are stupid and some are good, so you have to sort out where it belongs. And some stuff that customers bring up is really good, and then it can be smart to use it'. [Restaurant/bar]	X	
2.	I get a lot of ideas from the customers. They tell me what they miss. They absolutely do confront me with ideas. [Fitness instructor]	X	
3.	Doing our job you cannot just follow a template; you have to be flexible dealing with different customers. You have to be able to, to some extent, 'read' the customers. [Receptionist]	X	
4.	We see how they use their rooms and whether changes work or not. [Housekeeping]	X	
5.	I learn from my colleagues; for example new ways of doing massage. I can add this to my own way of doing my job. [Spa therapist]		X
6.	We are specialists in different fields, so we come up with ideas based on our expertise. [Spa therapist]		X
7.	We have a lot of extra staff who bring in new and fresh ideas. It becomes so that you catch on to [the idea of] 'yes, this is a much better way of doing it', because they may have been doing it like that in another workplace. … So you catch on to it, like 'but this is great, we do it like this'. [Restaurant/bar]		X
8.	Well, you get quite good feedback most of all from customers, that is one thing, but also from colleagues who talk to each other and toss ideas around. [Restaurant/bar]	X	X
9.	I think it is important that we can meet with all of the company's units. You get somewhat inside your own world, like the reception in one, we in another, and we may not think alike. So, actually, you should have regular meetings together, even if there are no particular issues that arise, because it will be useful. … I think it is very useful to talk to each other, to gain a joint understanding. [Fitness instructor]	X	X
10.	I read a lot, buy a lot of food magazines [and] wine and drink articles, because I am interested. Also I go online, and I am out a lot to check up dishes and drinks. [Restaurant/bar]	X	X
11.	It is us who work within the practice that now what works. [Restaurant/bar]	X	X
12.	… well, sometimes you feel like they [referring to management, our remark] decide things that may not work in the real life. You have to see how it actually works and not just decide one thing, […] you need to bring along someone who can explain how it is. [Receptionist]	X	X

job. As the quotations in Table 1 illustrate (e.g. no. 5–7), this is also quite evident in their ideas which are based on the FLEs' technology knowledge. More important is how employees' interaction with their co-workers enables them to increase their knowledge. By interacting and exchanging experiences, they learn from each other and build upon each other's ideas, rather like a brainstorming session. This is in particular related to the employees' closest colleagues within the same unit, but the interviews also point to the need for interaction across units. It is a way of getting 'everybody actively involved', as stated by an employee, and of sharing knowledge across practices (e.g. quotation no. 9 in Table 1).

As Table 1 illustrates (e.g. quotations no. 7 and 10), employees also gain both use and technology knowledge from being outside the organization; business trips, attending trade fairs, or observing firms within the same industry inspire new thinking. This is one way of preventing 'home blindness' as one respondent expressed it. Creativity is often connected to being able to 'think outside the box'. Being in the same working environment over a long period can reduce the ability to think beyond quotidian patterns, but by looking outside the company, employees are able to follow-up on trends, both in the market and within the profession. All respondents working as fitness instructors were convinced that being informed on fitness trends enabled them to renew both themselves and the programme they teach, and also to introduce new fitness styles or classes to the SPA-resort.

Summing up, the FLEs' domain knowledge is primarily based on knowledge of the practice and is augmented on the basis of interactions with customers and co-workers within the practice and organization. As seen, the knowledge is typically gained by 'doing their job', which in the case of FLEs indicates the combination of use knowledge and technology knowledge, a combination essential to innovative activity. Furthermore, the employees in general claim to possess an understanding of the organization and the customers from a different viewpoint than the management's, therefore enabling them to present ideas from an alternative perspective (e.g. quotations no. 11–12 in Table 1). Their knowledge of the customers combined with the knowledge of the routines within the practice and service delivery processes thus presents the opportunity to initiate something new to the organization, which will be addressed later in the findings.

Creative skills

Individuals are different when it comes to being creative, which reflects their creative skills. The concept of creative skills refers to the individual's personality as well as how a person works and thinks. The interviews did not provide the possibility of a thorough analysis of this factor, but differences between the employees did appear in the data. Some employees came up with ideas constantly and could have inspired co-workers, while others were more satisfied doing what they usually do:

> … I am not the kind of person who takes a lot of initiative, […] I think it is ok when it runs smoothly; that is the kind of person I am. [Spa therapist]

On the other hand, there were the employees who characterized themselves with a drive to take initiative and to be creative, which was expressed by two interviewees from the spa and fitness unit:

> I have a lot of ideas and I cannot be silent. I just have to let them out. … If I have an opinion, I express it. And then they can either relate to it or not. But at least I have said what I wanted and expressed my ideas. And that feels important to me. [Fitness instructor]
>
> I think I am a creative person who tries to see opportunities and not focuses on problems. ... That is who I am as a person. [Fitness instructor]

As mentioned earlier, the interviews were insufficient for measuring the employees' creative skills, since they were self-reports. Also, the employees differed from one another. The unit managers acknowledged these differences by ascribing to their staff different attitudes regarding the contribution of ideas and being involved in the development of the resort. Irrespective of the employees' skill, the factor of motivation was essential for everyone, and will be addressed in the next section.

Motivation

As we have seen, the literature on organizational creativity emphasizes the importance of intrinsic motivation. Intrinsically motivated FLEs are those who have an inner drive for their job, a passion for what they do, as opposed to extrinsically motivated employees who primarily are driven by rewards or a fear of penalties. The factor that is the most apparent among the interviewees can be illustrated from the following quotation:

> For me the thought of a reward sounds ridiculous. It is not about competing. If you get an idea, it is not just about you, but everyone. [Spa therapist]

Several employees raised the same point: rewards are not necessary. The reward seemed to lie primarily in being satisfied, enjoying the job, and improving the service for themselves, the workplace, and the customers. The following sample of quotations illustrates the FLEs' view.

> I feel engrossed with my job. You want to do your best and to solve problems, to make sure that the customer is satisfied. … I enjoy working with people. [Receptionist 1]
>
> I am satisfied when the customer is satisfied. [Receptionist 2]
>
> I live for fitness and training – I think that is my 'calling' in life. [Fitness instructor]
>
> I take a huge interest in what I do at work. [Restaurant/bar]

In general, the employees seem to be driven by the job and the work practice. Moreover, the ideas do not seem to be so much about individual gain, but about fellowship. As one spa therapist stated, 'when you have an idea it is not just about you, but everyone you work with'. Being motivated is not a static state, independent of the social environment. At the SPA-resort, we see that social interaction is not just about gaining knowledge, but it also seems essential for creating an environment conducive for the sharing of ideas:

> You hear others having ideas, like one guy whom I am working with downstairs at the bar; he is very innovative with different things. So he pushed me and then it just became like 'yes, I just got an idea' and then I expressed the idea. [Restaurant/bar]

Working together inspired employees to come up with ideas. In general, they expressed a preference for being creative and generating ideas in collaboration with others. The employees commented that a lack of having regular meetings within and across the units was a disadvantage, both in general and for generating ideas specifically.

The importance of support from co-workers is also emphasized in the interviews. Receiving feedback seems to strengthen confidence, which again stimulates new ideas. It triggers the employees into a positive cycle, which one respondent stated when explaining the reasons for why the ideas kept coming up:

> I think it is like this, that I have received a response and have been shown trust by my managers and my colleagues. You get feedback, like 'yes, this works well', and that makes you dare to take the next step. [Fitness instructor]

This quotation illustrates an important point. Merely having the ability to generate ideas does not imply that people do; there is also the ingredient of feeling confident that your attempts to innovate will be well received. Equally important as having supportive co-workers is receiving support from the management. It is noteworthy that the employees expressed an understanding that their ideas might not be prioritized and not implemented, but they believed it was important to learn why their ideas were not applied. In short, feedback is essential. Reflecting upon what hampers idea creation, one employee stated:

> That no one listens. I understand that they cannot take in everything and go through with everything. But just to say, 'yes, we have listened, it is a good idea or we will try to do something

> about it. Do you have any ideas on how to get there?' But it does not get there. They just 'yes, yes'. And then there is nothing more and you hear no more of it. [Fitness instructor]

Other respondents expressed similar thoughts. It seemed essential in many ways that the unit manager listened and gave feedback. These practices appeared to spark the process of creating ideas while also providing a mutual understanding of the acceptance or rejection of the ideas. Without managerial feedback, employees might easily get caught up in a negative circle, as is illustrated by the following quotation:

> It is difficult, I think; it is very difficult to influence. You may tell your ideas and point of view and nothing happens, so finally you become silent, unable or unwilling to do that anymore. [Housekeeping]

There also seems to be a mutual agreement among the employees that communication should follow the formal lines within the organization. Consequently, ideas are passed on to the unit manager and their leadership style will to a great degree influence the work environment and the employees' motivation, which will be discussed in the next section.

Idea management

The next phase depicts the further processing of the ideas, which is basically a management-controlled activity. As seen in Figure 2, some ideas were never dispatched to the unit manager but were instead informally implemented directly by the FLEs. Other ideas could, however, not be implemented directly because the FLEs did not have the resources or the authority to do so. The FLEs instead presented the ideas to their unit managers, who became the 'owner' for their further processing. The manager could either immediately reject the idea or decide to proceed with further development and implementation. If the idea did not affect any other unit the managers pursued the idea on their own; otherwise they had to present it to the CEO (or the top managerial group). The unit managers were thus gatekeepers with a great impact on the creative process and the outcome. They were found not only to select ideas, but, as the previous section showed, also to influence the FLEs' motivation a great deal and thereby the generation of ideas.

The role of gatekeeper took different shapes depending on the three unit managers' diverse attitudes of valuing employees' ideas and contribution. The spa/fitness unit had the most structured and methodical manner with respect to idea creation and innovation, and the spa manager was also convinced that the FLEs had the best ideas. The following quotation illustrates the developmental process and the manager's attitude:

> … I started up developmental groups at the unit to come up with ideas within different areas of expertise such as skin therapy, massage, spa therapy, and training. […] The best ideas come from the personnel, guaranteed. They interact with the customers and that is where from you learn. [Spa manager]

The spa unit's employees could devote some hours per month to take part in innovative activities, such as tossing ideas around and discussing development. Two issues seemed most important for the manager during the evaluation of the ideas. First, there was the question of whether the idea resonated with the newly decided strategic brand image of the spa hotel as a sport and wellness resort. This quotation demonstrates this point:

> … now it is much easier to say "no" to ideas that doesn't fit our concept sport & wellness.

The other issue was profitability, including both estimated cost and revenue. The manager had the competence to make these evaluations and decisions, but wanted the employees to learn to think in terms of profitability. After the manager had selected the most promising ideas, it was actually the employees who first evaluated them. They were asked to investigate if the idea would be feasible and potentially profitable.

> It is very easy to say to me: "Boss we should do this and that". But instead of me looking into and assessing if it is good I threw the ball back to them …
>
> They get it [the idea] back to investigate … would it be feasible, profitable, what would we gain, what would the objectives be, etc.? … They work in teams with the issue and I support them if needed. … in this processes about 50 per cent of the ideas are discarded by the group. … Interestingly I have noticed that they tend to think more and more cost-effectively as time goes by. [Spa manager]

The spa manager had thus created an environment where the employees gradually learned more about issues of cost and feasibility and gained a better understanding of what makes ideas suitable for further development. According to the spa manager, the number of ideas had decreased over time but the quality had improved. The manager thought that the reduction in ideas was due to the employees' not putting forward ideas that they had learned were not suitable.

A striking contrast to the spa unit was the hotel/reception, which had virtually no specifically structured activities for generating ideas and developing new services. The whole unit had a strict focus on reducing costs. Even when it came to introducing new services, the hotel manager expressed concerns. The development was instead reactive; therefore, problems that occurred in the course of daily operations were dealt with haphazardly, as expressed by the following:

> It is easy to come up with new ideas, but we often forget to look into the costs side. […] I think we have a rather broad offer already. [Hotel manager]

No proactive activities for coming up with new ideas could be discerned at the hotel/reception unit. Innovation was a term not spoken of, but there were activities in sharing problems and issues that had arisen during the daily operations.

> If there is a problem at any of the departments it is brought forward at the unit's regular meetings. We discuss what can be done about it. This is not really development … the trigger is normally an incident in the daily operation that needs to be corrected. [Hotel manager]

The manager expressed an attitude that the hotel and reception had very little opportunity to be innovative and to come up with creative ideas. The main indicator of performance was the efficiency of the employees.

> To me the most important performance indicator is efficiency of the employees. … We are a large-scale production … . we must try to do this in a standardized way; it is not just possible to customize this. [Hotel manager]

The food and beverage manager's attitude lay in between the other two units. The manager was also engaged in stimulating the employees' creativity, but not as systematically as the spa/fitness unit. In this regard, listening and giving feedback were essential issues, which are illustrated by the following quotations:

> I think the most important condition for my employees to come up with new ideas is that their boss listens to them and that it makes a difference. … if you decide to reject an idea you need to take time to explain why, otherwise you will kill their willingness to come up with new ideas. [Food and beverage manager]

The manager also put a lot of trust into the employees' ability actually to be creative and saw his/her own role more as being responsible for the profitability, as indicated by this quotation regarding how new menus were created:

> There is a team in the kitchen, approximately half of the staff, who suggests the menus […]; they brainstorm and then present their menu suggestions to me. We then make a cost-estimate of the suggestion and make a go/no-go decision. [Food and beverage manager]

The final decision was thus based upon an economical calculus, but the employees were allowed to be creative and come up with new concepts. The process was, however, less formalized and structured than was the case with the spa unit.

Emerging from the data were thus three different approaches to managing and stimulating idea creation and innovation that emerged, spanning from focal, proactive activities to problem-fixing tactics. It seemed that the CEO was aware of this imbalance between the units, stating that:

> … I think it's the spa [unit] that is in the forefront of innovation here. They do have a small board for dealing with innovation and developmental issues, especially regarding therapy. Many ideas come from there. [CEO]

At the same time, the CEO was aware that not all of the units could have the same conditions for enabling innovative work. The CEO himself is by the other managers considered as being a real innovator in respect of coming up with new ideas. As one of the managers stated: 'Our CEO is a visionary and has fantastic ideas; he's a starter'. But at the SPA-resort, the CEO is dependent on the unit managers for the reception of ideas from the front line. Consequently, ideas pass through the formal channels of communication, and this structure affects the ideas that are eventually implemented.

Implementation

Figure 2 illustrates two diverse paths for implementing the FLEs' ideas, namely formal and informal implementations. The difference between the two is primarily based on who controls the resources needed for implementation. As Figure 2 shows, the path for informal implantation is ideas that are neither presented to nor evaluated by management. These ideas do not need to go through management because the employees themselves control the resources needed to implement them. The formal path to implementation indicates the opposite. Here the employees need approval or resources, or both, in order to develop and implement the idea. We can better understand the differences between the two paths by examining the type of ideas created by the employees.

Though the ideas that are informally implemented vary, they share some common characteristics. The ideas can to a large extent be considered as incremental, as small improvements. The ideas often arise from employees doing their job and are considered to be small adjustments in the service or the service delivery. They may be planned or emerge as a solution to a problem in the job's practices. As an example, a FLE working at the restaurant reported the following innovation:

> They are kind of small solutions; we try out new ways – things that might make things easier – or when new things arise like this weekend: we had 120 guests dining downstairs, and there were not enough tables and the place was packed. Because the cash register is not designed to handle so many guests, we had to come up with a new solution based on using guests' room numbers in order to serve and register them. And it worked out very well, much better than if we had done it the ordinary way. [Restaurant/bar]

The quotation above illustrates in many ways a typical idea described by the respondents. An idea was created to solve an unforeseen problem that arose in the service delivery process. The employees used the resources at hand to change the regular routine, and thus these were instances of informal innovation processes as previously discussed. We can classify these actions as instances of bricolage innovation. The mentioning of these informal processes appeared quite regularly in the interviews, and they seemed to be a way for employees to adjust the service delivery continuously and in some ways ensured the flexibility of the process and the customization of the service delivered.

Thus, it could be said that the ideas in some way altered the employees' practices. The ideas were set in the workplace and when they were implemented, the practice was changed, not radically but by small adjustments to the service process or to the service concept. As one employee expressed it;

> 'It is about our way of doing our job. That is also what I get ideas about.' [Receptionist]

The formal path to innovation is, as mentioned, based on ideas that require resources that the employees do not fully control in order to be implemented. These types of ideas need a more advanced developmental process. An example from SPA-resort was the spa therapist who suggested a 'coffee corner shop with fitness-related products' as a new service concept, or the fitness instructor who suggested a new type of fitness session. The idea for a coffee shop illustrates a developmental process that goes beyond the resources in control of the FLEs. The process of implementing this idea would require both financial and human resources, as well as the involvement of different units within the organization. The fitness instructor's idea of adding a new session is similar in the sense that the further innovation process also requires additional resources. Thus, these examples depict a formal path to innovation since the development and the implementation of these ideas would necessitate the initiation of an organizational innovation process.

Discussion and conclusion

There has been a call for studies that can give greater depth to the understanding of the service innovation process (Crevani et al., 2011; Zhou & Shalley, 2003); this study has responded to this call by investigating on a micro-level the seminal creative phase of FLEs' generation of ideas and their further development into potential implementation in the organization. Studying the innovation process from a bottom-up perspective allows us to understand how FLEs act as innovators more fully.

The study primarily makes two contributions regarding FLEs and service innovation. (1) The first relates to the influence of knowledge for making FLEs apt as innovators. In this study, we have drawn upon previous works from creativity research (Amabile, 1988) and have added a deeper understanding to the concept of domain-relevant knowledge, with regard to both the type of knowledge and the mechanisms that build this knowledge. (2) The second contribution comprises both our distinguishing between multiple service innovations processes within the organization that involve FLEs and our identifying of the crucial role of the middle manager for managing the service innovation processes, conceptualized as 'weaving'. The implications of these results are of both a theoretical and a practical nature and we address them next.

Front-line employees as an idea creator

The study suggests that FLEs possess a considerable innovative capacity, that is, the potential to innovate. This capacity can be understood within the same framework as individual creativity in general, which is based on the factors of creative skills, domain knowledge, and motivation. This finding supports previous research on employee creativity (see e.g. Zhou & Shalley, 2003). However, this study also elaborates on what makes FLEs unique, namely, their boundary-spanning role in the interface between company and customer. The empirical data illustrate how this position enables them to absorb both use knowledge and technology knowledge, both considered necessary for one to become innovative (von Hippel, 1994). Customers are considered as having more use knowledge and providers more technology knowledge. Our study identifies how FLEs through their work practice actually gain sufficient use knowledge that can be combined with their technology knowledge in order to propose new ideas for services. Although previous research has emphasized the importance of involving FLEs in innovation processes (de Brentani, 2001; Ordanini & Parasuraman, 2011), this study contributes with a more thorough understanding of what contributions FLEs can make with regard to service innovation. Their knowledge of both the demand and the supply side is to a great extent limited to the context of their work practice, and the ideas are primarily related to the development of existing practices and resources.

The results indicate that the knowledge held by the FLEs is to a great extent unknown to the middle and top management, and this enables the organization to obtain a new perspective. However, this assumes that FLEs' ideas are validated and implemented. As shown in this study, there are multiple paths for implementation, informal or ad hoc, where empowered employees can solve problems that arise by using resources under their control (e.g. bricolage innovation). Yet there is also a more formal process that relies on dispatching the idea to the manager because it requires a managerial decision for it to be implemented. This dual aspect reflects the nature of service innovation being partly intertwined with the organizational structures and processes in the company, confirming previous studies (Fuglsang & Sørensen, 2011; Sundbo, 2008; Toivonen & Tuominen, 2009). A service innovation always requires some new or modified resource or practice, or both, to be adopted by the firm. The FLEs have the knowledge and the ideas, but the middle manager holds the key to whether the ideas will be further developed into innovations.

Innovation management by 'weaving'

In the locus of the service innovation processes stands the middle (unit) manager with a key role. Their role for supporting organizational creativity and innovation is in general known in the literature (Amabile et al., 2004; de Jong & Vermeulen, 2003; Shalley & Gilson, 2004; Sundbo, 2008). In the study by Fuglsang and Sørensen (2011), the role of middle managers is evident as the link between top-management-initiated innovation and employee-initiated innovation (defined as bricolage). In the SPA-resort, we observe how diverse ideas have different paths to implementation, thus confirming Fuglsang and Sørensen's (2011) notion of multiple innovation processes. Our study goes deeper into the middle manager's role on a micro-level and unveils the complexity of their innovation-related task due to having to balance between multiple, sometimes conflicting, roles. The study thus provides a deeper understanding of how the processes identified in recent research can be managed in order to foster innovation in the organization, from informal and formal paths to the implementation of ideas.

The middle-management roles can be identified as *facilitators* of the FLEs' efforts to innovate: 'I have started up development groups in my department', [Spa manager]; as *gatekeepers*; 'It is important to take the time to explain why we cannot develop the idea further', [Food and beverage manager]; and finally as *translators* to FLEs of the top management's strategic intentions:

> I do experience that when we in the management group have decided on something, I automatically assume that the information is being communicated to and within the different units.

> Then, when things are not followed up, I discover that the information never came through. [CEO]

The same type of functions can be found in the literature, for instance Amabile et al. (2004), on leadership support. Nonaka (1994) identifies the middle managers as the link for communicating 'middle-up-down' and Zhou and Woodman (2003) conceptualize the importance of managers' recognition of the employees' ideas. However, our study strongly suggests that the key lies in being able to handle them simultaneously. The middle manager needs to find a balance between these roles – facilitator, gatekeeper, and translator – in order to support the necessary implementation of small ideas that the FLEs can manage on their own and to encourage the employees to bring their ideas forward so that they can undergo a process of further development. At the same time, they have to make sure that the practice and the organization are on the same path, in both the long and short runs.

A way of understanding how the middle (unit) managers deal with these challenges is by introducing the metaphor of 'weaving'. A service operation can be seen as a number of concurrent processes or practices that deliver services in interaction with the customers. Each process or practice can be thought of as a thread. Together, the threads form a weaving, representing the organization's service system. In different ways – for example, interacting and observing – the FLEs discover deficiencies or new possibilities in the service weaving on a micro-level. New threads need to be added or existing ones need to be changed. Some of these changes can be managed by the FLEs themselves, a practice known as bricolage innovation. However, some new threads cannot be woven without the support from the middle manager, because the FLEs do not have access and control of the resources needed to make the changes. The unit manager holds the key for letting those threads become a part of the existing pattern in the weaving. An important point is that though the threads are woven from the bottom-up by the FLEs, the main pattern in the weaving (strategic course) is primarily decided by the management. The strategic course defines which threads are suitable, and it also the top management's decisions that decides the design for future weavings. Our study identified one such design pattern or model as the new 'sport and wellness' concept for the resort. The pattern design can be a help for the middle managers in their decision to select appropriate ideas by reflecting over whether they are apt, as expressed by the spa manager concerning the assessment of strategic fit of FLEs' ideas.

Metaphorically, the employees bring in their ideas, their threads, which must be compatible with the existing threads in the work practice and the overall pattern for the organization defined by the top management. The middle managers must be able to facilitate the creative process, and at the same time they must discard some ideas in their role as gatekeepers. Furthermore, the middle manager must tend to the development of the practice while also making sure that the daily service processes are running smoothly. Thus, as stated earlier, middle management is not just about one role, but multiple roles that may conflict. But as we see at the SPA-resort, there is a thin line between creating a positive cycle that fosters an environment that motivates employees to create and bring ideas forward versus a negative one that leads to the opposite. The latter, where a manager is not able to take on the roles, can thus leave the organization with loose threads and a poorer pattern.

Practical implications

For practitioners, this study provides relevant insights regarding the role of FLEs as innovators. From this study, it should be understood that FLEs have the potential for being innovators of new services owing to their possessing a unique combination of use and technology knowledge. This knowledge is primarily based on the FLEs' work practice, and when it is transformed into ideas it represents a new perspective to the organization. In order to transform the FLEs' innovative potential into service innovations, the organization needs to be actively engaged in innovation activities that include employees at all levels of the organization. Although FLEs are not employed to be innovators, their work and knowledge give them a role in the organization's innovation arena. The study has shown that minor innovations can be accomplished if FLEs have the authority to implement ideas as opportunities arise (i.e. informal implementation). However, going beyond, for example, bricolage innovations, the ideas need further processing, and here FLEs have a more limited opportunity to realize their ideas. There is thus a need to establish some kind of formalized structure and process for managing upcoming ideas from FLEs. Although this study identifies middle managers as having a key role in the transformation of ideas into practicable service innovations, the organization's top management needs to establish the emphasis on acknowledging the FLEs' ideas. These processes will require resources and it is also vital for middle managers to have organizational support and established follow-up routines in order to accomplish the implementation of ideas.

Furthermore, middle managers need to be aware of their active role in nurturing innovation; in fact we identified three different roles: *facilitator*, *gatekeeper*, and *translator*. FLEs need facilitation in order to be motivated and to be creative. This can be accomplished by creating arenas for innovative work, such as in the spa unit of this study. In these arenas, employees can meet, discuss, and learn, not just within the unit but also across the organization. This is important for triggering more and better ideas, consequently making the gatekeeper role easier to manage. Furthermore, creating work and development groups across the units can be one step to establishing shared ownership of ideas and the innovation process. Finally, the middle manager's role as translator of the strategic issues is central for creating a mutual direction for the different innovation processes that continuously take place in a service organization. It is neither possible nor desirable for the managers to control all the processes (e.g. bricolage innovations), but by ensuring that also FLEs are aware of (relevant) strategic choices, the middle manager creates a guide for FLEs' ideas. It is thus essential for middle managers to understand that they must undertake new activities in order to nurture innovation; FLEs' knowledge and ideas need to be recognized and the processes of further development must become a part of the managers' agenda.

Future research

The study is based on empirical data from one organization, comparing three different departments. The choice of an in-depth study of an explorative nature is, however, done at the expense of the generalizability of the study's findings. There is therefore a need for further studies in order to establish to what extent this study's results apply to other similar settings. Furthermore, studies should be conducted on different kinds of businesses in order to gain more knowledge on the role of FLEs in creativity and innovation. From our study, it is quite clear that the middle managers play a decisive role in service innovation and represent the link between FLEs' ideas and the implantation. There is much to be learned about middle managers' practices in organizations that successfully incorporate FLEs' ideas, when it comes to their role in creating a nurturing and supporting environment and their role as gatekeeper.

As many FLEs' innovations are ad hoc solutions to an unexpected problem, researchers should try to learn more about the practices that enable the quick fix to be transformed into an institutionalized service innovation to be used in the daily practices. Through more research, we might find a balance that allows firms to capture the implementation of innovations that occur beneath the radar (or control) of management so that organizations do not miss out on ideas that should be managed as part of the organizational innovation process.

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